

Bazaar



We test the latest and the best hardware and software products available in the market

Tungsten T and Zire

Palmistry: Fated to change the way you perceive a handheld

Here are two products from Palm that could not be more different from each other. The fact that one of them is meant for the corporate power-user (the kind that eats spreadsheets for lunch) while the other for the humble student (the kind that skips lunch for pending assignments) is apparent from the onset. Marvel at the smooth metallic finish of the Tungsten T (corporate grey, to go with the pinstripe suits); a form factor tiny enough for a snug fit within the palm of your hand and inside your shirt pocket; and a clear sleeve of tough, transparent plastic for very effective screen protection. While the Tungsten T would be at home in a board meeting, there's the Zire too that is all attitude and screams trendy, with a bright silver-white and grey colour tone and a sturdy plastic casing that benefits the device with a very light weight. Screen protection on the Zire is afforded by a blue rubber flap which, while functioning adequately, is also a real pain since it gets in the way while the device is in use.

Turn the handhelds on and the philosophy behind the looks extends to what lies beneath—the operating system. The Tungsten thus stays at the forefront of innovation thanks to the new Palm OS 5.0. Apart from support for faster ARM-based processors, the OS also extends a helping hand to the Tungsten's excellent display screen—a 320x320

resolution, 16-bit TFT that is admirably supported by sharper, more readable fonts, spruced up icons and new applications. While improved stability and backward-compatibility is advertised, a few old applications did manage to bring this device crashing down.



The Palm Tungsten T

Pros: Small form factor, Bluetooth connectivity, one handed navigation, excellent display screen, good software bundle

Cons: Costly, limited multimedia features

The Zire sticks to the tried and tired OS 4.1, packed with just enough features for the entry-level product that it is. This low-end handheld is very stable and can theoretically run the many thousands of applications that are available for the older OS. Theoretically, since the Zire is seriously limited by a meagre 2 MB of storage capacity (non-expandable at that), it cannot run decent games or office applications.

Another impeding implementation for the Zire is that it sports a non-standard number of buttons on its face. While the Tungsten T has the usual four-button layout, in addition to a new and useful five-way navigator, the Zire finds itself two buttons short of the norm. This further takes away from the list of applications that this handheld can run, since certain software such as games do require the four-button layout. Both the devices are easily navigated; although the five-

tions as the Select key. This configuration is great for games and allows you to use the Tungsten with just one hand. Zipping between applications could have been even faster on this device with a more intelligent implementation of the Select button.

Input of data on both these devices is done via the stylus and Graffiti. The latter is a means of entering letters by using the stylus—while some learning is involved, the process is fairly intuitive. However, it isn't time-effective—there is only so much you can type at a stretch when you are entering data one letter at a time! For those weaned on the keyboard, Palm does offer a foldable, pocket-sized QWERTY peripheral for the Tungsten T. Users of the Zire would have to be content with Graffiti since the device does not have a Universal Connector where peripherals such as a keyboard might dock.

The Zire is evidently a very lean device, built for one thing alone: personal information management (PIM). As such, all the usual suspects are present: Address Book, Date Book, Clock, To Do List, Memo Pad, Note Pad, Calculator and Expense; an e-book reader is sourly missed. With PIM applications such as these, the 2 MB storage capacity seems more than enough to store some 6,000 addresses and five years of appointments, with room for more. Moreover, games such as *Mine Hunt* and *Hardball*

	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Q1 TOT	Q2 TOT
1	100	120	150	180	200	220	450	500
2	110	130	160	190	210	230	500	550
3	120	140	170	200	220	240	550	600
4	130	150	180	210	230	250	600	650
5	140	160	190	220	240	260	650	700
6	150	170	200	230	250	270	700	750
7	160	180	210	240	260	280	750	800
8	170	190	220	250	270	290	800	850
9	180	200	230	260	280	300	850	900
10	190	210	240	270	290	310	900	950
11	200	220	250	280	300	320	950	1000
12	210	230	260	290	310	330	1000	1050
TOTAL	2100	2310	2520	2730	2940	3150	10500	11550